

Travels in Italy

In 1420, Dufay traveled to Italy to take up a post in the service of the Malatesta family in Rimini. This allowed him to further his career in the Church and to broaden his musical horizons, coming into contact with the latest developments of the nascent Italian Renaissance musical style.

From Rimini, he moved to Bologna, where he was ordained as a priest in 1428, and then went on to Rome to join the papal choir. By this time, he had made a name for himself as a composer and managed to secure a series of prestigious posts: maître de chapelle (choirmaster) in the court of Savoy, under Duke Amédée VIII (later Antipope Felix V); then at the papal chapel in Florence; and finally in the service of the Este family in Ferrara.

Throughout the 1430s, political turmoil between the papacy and the Council of Basel rocked the Catholic Church, and Dufay's position in Italy became insecure. In about 1440, he returned to Cambrai to supervise music at the cathedral, and also made connections with the court of Philip the Good of Burgundy (see [box](#)).

A new style of music

Dufay was considered to be one of the finest composers in Europe at that time, known for both his sacred and his secular compositions. He pioneered the composition of complete Masses based on a single chant or melody ("cyclical" Masses)—often the tune of a popular secular song, or one of his own chansons. With his colleague Gilles Binchois, he established a highly distinctive